

Genre: First person shooter
 Studio: Bungie
 Publisher: Microsoft Game Studios
 *Platforms: Xbox 360

Halo Reach takes the player to the birthplace of Spartan program and one of humanities most populous and prosperous space colonies. The story explores the last few days of Planet Reach's defense against the full force of the mighty Covenant war-machine. It follows the exploits of a team of Spartans soldiers called Noble Team, and the player takes on the role of Noble Six.

This is how we do it

Halo Reach's goodness is not just in its emotive storytelling, but the action is just as engaging. If you liked the game-play changes made with *Halo 3* over its predecessors, then chances are good that you will enjoy *Reach* all the more. A significant and interesting addition in *Halo Reach* is Armor Abilities. Extending over the concept of equipment which was introduced in *Halo 3*, Armor Abilities are reusable pick-ups with a cool-down timer. There are a total of seven such abilities in the game, but the player can equip only one at any time. Effective use of these abilities becomes crucial during certain set-pieces in the Campaign mode on higher difficulties. On 'Heroic' difficulty level — which happens to be the recommended level — the

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enemy AI is quite efficient at flanking and cornering. This mixes well with the game's level design which has a fair bit of variety. Between the arsenal of human and Covenant weapons, vehicles, mounted weapons and Armor Abilities, there is a good deal of combinations and strategies to experiment with. This keeps things fresh and challenging right till you fire your last bullet.

Reach online

The *Halo* series owes much of its fame to the series' multiplayer component and *Reach* has been built well around that tradition. Bungie has extended the Service Record and armor customization options, along with commendation, in a new credits-based content unlocking system. The sheer number of multiplayer game types and game customization options available in *Halo Reach* is very impressive and could very well be

unique, at least among console games.

We played *Halo Reach* on Xbox Live using the free two-day Gold Access card that comes with the game, on a 1 mbps connection. The experience was without glitches and completely lag-free. One exception to an otherwise solid system is a standalone program called *Halo Waypoint*. This is meant to serve as a hub for all Xbox 360 releases of *Halo* games. This program consolidated Service Records and Achievements from *Halo Wars*, *Halo 3*, *Halo ODS*T and *Halo Reach* into one epic career record. Unfortunately, the system appears to be broken or reeling under a lot of traffic, as we experienced constant disconnects with the server after every minute or so. There may be more to *Halo Waypoint*, but it's hard to tell when the system is not playing nice.

Halo Reach has earned its reputation as the killer-app for the Xbox 360 with its immersive single-player campaign, coupled with wide variety of multiplayer options. If you have ever loved a shooter, this game deserves your attention even if you not particularly a fan of the series. 



Halo 3 boasts of emotive storytelling



You'll find the enemy's AI quite challenging